

# Earwax - Male (Child)

Algorithm 1403 | Child (0-17 years) | Gender at birth: Male

## Definition

- Qatar-localized UAT-only adult and pediatric pathway for suspected earwax, screening for sudden hearing loss, infection, perforation, foreign body and contraindications to irrigation or drops.
- Child patient.
- Male.

## Initial assessment

1. [DURATION] How long has the blockage been present?
2. [YES\_NO] Any pain, discharge, or bleeding from the ear?
3. [OPEN\_TEXT] Has anything already been tried, including drops, irrigation, candles or cotton buds?
4. [OPEN\_TEXT] What is the exact age; is the patient pregnant; and are there sudden hearing loss, pain, discharge, bleeding, dizziness, previous perforation/surgery, tubes, diabetes, immune suppression, foreign body or safeguarding concerns?
5. [CAREGIVER\_OBSERVATION] What has a safe parent or caregiver observed about alertness, breathing, pain, swelling, fever, eating or drinking, sleep, play, and normal activity?

## Triage and redirect questions

### **1. Redirect → Earache**

Is ear pain, discharge, fever, or acute illness the main concern rather than wax blockage?

Ear pain or acute ear illness belongs in the Earache pathway.

### **1. Disposition level 70**

Have symptoms lasted more than 5 days despite home treatment, or is there a severe blockage preventing hearing?

NHS.UK earwax guidance recommends primary-care review for symptoms lasting more than 5 days or a severe hearing blockage.

### **1. Disposition level 50**

Is this a recent, mild earwax blockage with none of the features above?

NHS.UK guidance recommends softening oil drops as first-line home treatment.

## Advice

### **Urgent earwax review**

- Arrange review by a primary-care clinician or nurse - the wax may need professional removal by irrigation, microsuction, or gentle scraping.
- Call Back If: pain or discharge develops.

### **Assessment before earwax treatment**

- Do not insert objects, use ear candles or irrigate the ear. Arrange clinician/pharmacist review before drops are selected because age, eardrum status, surgery/tubes, infection, pregnancy and allergies must be checked.
- Call Back If: sudden hearing loss; pain, discharge, bleeding, fever or dizziness.

## First aid

## References

- NHS.UK, "Earwax build-up", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/earwax-build-up/> (page last reviewed 05 January 2024)

## Provenance

Shaped to mirror the licensed After-Hours Telehealth Triage Guidelines database structure. This is IST open-source guideline content derived from cited public sources; it is not licensed STCC content. Question.DispositionLevel=null marks a See More Appropriate Guideline redirect. Demographic variants contain only source-supported differences; identical thresholds are documented rather than fabricated. Local destinations and TelemedicineEligible values require IST clinical governance approval. UAT DATA ONLY - NOT FOR REAL-PATIENT CARE OR PRODUCTION USE.

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